Marketing 101 for Sanghas

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A reference guide from the Dharma Teacher Weekend 2026 Marketing 101 session, led by Edahn Small (edahn.small@gmail.com) and Solomiya Martynovych (SolomiyaM@gmail.com).

Think like a marketer (a little)

It doesn't need to be icky

Marketing for a sangha isn't selling. It means seeing your group through a stranger's eyes and clearing the obstacles between them and the cushion.

Basic ideas

- **Audience.** Who are you trying to reach? Curious beginners, stressed professionals, students, people already practicing elsewhere. Evaluate things from THEIR perspective using your best guess or actually soliciting feedback.
- **Touchpoints.** Every place someone meets you: Google, your website, an email, the front door, the person who greets them.
- **The funnel.** The path from first hearing about you to becoming a regular. Some people drop off at each stage, but why?



The newcomer funnel · 5 stages

Exercise: The Newcomers' Perspective

What's it like to be a newcomer who discovers your sitting group or sangha?

- Who is your audience? Picture one person to represent each group (a persona).
- What state of mind are they in? What are they looking for?
- The journey:
  - DISCOVERY & RESEARCH: What's the first touchpoint they encounter?
    What would make them have a good experience? What would make them have a bad experience? (confusing, doesn't look inviting, information hard to find, price, culty vibes)
  - FIRST VISIT: What happens when they first join you live or via Zoom?
    What happens when it goes well? Why might it not go well?
  - What do people need to continue to return?
    Belonging? Friendship? Results? Good interactions?

Common Problems and Solutions

What the newcomer thinks	The fix
"I can't find when they sit."	Sitting times on the home page and on Google.
"The calendar still shows last spring."	Update it monthly. Delete old events.
"Is this a religion? Do I have to be Buddhist?"	Say it plainly: everyone is welcome, no belief required.
"What do I wear? Where do I go? Do I have to bow?"	A short "Your first visit" page.
"I don't know what kong-an, Kyol Che or JDPSN mean."	Plain words first. Teach the term after.
"Everyone knew the forms. I felt lost."	A 10-minute orientation before the first sit. A greeter who sits nearby.
"Nobody talked to me."	One person greets each newcomer and invites them to tea.
"I emailed and never heard back."	One named person replies within 2 days.
"5 AM and 108 bows? That's too intense for me."	Point to an easy first step: an evening sit or intro night.
"Does it cost money?"	State the cost or suggested donation. Say no one is turned away.
"I couldn't find the door or parking."	Directions plus a photo of the entrance.
"Is this group legit?"	An About page: the Kwan Um School, the teacher, how long you've met.
"It looks cold and serious."	Real photos of real people, with permission. A warm tone.

5 things you can do today

Every sitting group can do these in a month, for free. Tick them off as you go.

- [ ] **Google Business Profile.** When someone searches "meditation near me" or "Zen center," this is what they see first: your name, map pin, hours and photos. Claim it at business.google.com.

- [ ] **A simple website.** One page is enough: who you are, when you sit, where, what it costs, and how to reach you. Keep it current.
- [ ] **A "Your first visit" section.** What happens, how long it lasts, what to wear, where to go, and that no experience is needed.
- [ ] **Real photos.** The room, the entrance, people sitting together. Ask permission first.
- [ ] **One person who answers.** A named contact for email and phone, who replies within 2 days and greets newcomers at the door.

Going further

Once the essentials are solid, these keep people coming back and help new people find you.

Newsletter

- Send one email a month. Short beats long.
- Include: upcoming sits and retreats, one short teaching or quote, a photo, and one way to get involved.
- Add a sign-up sheet by the door and a form on your website.

Engagement

- Thank people by name after retreats and events.
- Invite newcomers to one small job: tea, greeting, setting up cushions. Belonging comes from helping.
- Ask for feedback once a year: what brought you, what almost kept you away.
- Hold an occasional intro night or open house, and invite friends.

Instagram and TikTok

- Pick one platform and do it well. Instagram suits most sanghas; TikTok reaches younger people.
- Post once a week. Short videos get the most reach.
- Show real practice and real people. Always ask before filming anyone.
- Keep the tone warm and simple. Ask questions in captions.

Content ideas

Idea	Format
"What happens at your first sit"	30-second video walking through the room
How to sit: posture in 60 seconds	Short video
A short teaching or kong-an, in plain words	Quote card or caption
Meet a member: why I practice	Photo + a few lines
Behind the scenes: setting up, tea, cleaning	Photos or short video
What the bell, moktak and chanting mean	Short explainer video
Retreat or event recap	Photo carousel
Myth vs. fact: "Do I have to empty my mind?"	Carousel or video
Upcoming events	Story or post, a week ahead

Guiding principles

Good marketing for a sangha looks a lot like good practice.

Principle	What it means
Consistency	Show up on a rhythm: same sit times, monthly newsletter, weekly post. Small and steady beats big and rare.
Reliability	What you say is true. Times are current, emails get answered, the door is open when you say.
Clarity	Plain words. A stranger should understand every sentence.
Warmth	Sound like a friendly person, not an institution.
Authenticity	Show who you really are. No hype, no stock photos.
Generosity	Give first: teachings, tips, a welcome. Don't only ask.

Principle	What it means
Don't-know mind	Test, ask newcomers, and change what isn't working.

Free tools

All of these have a free option. Start with one or two.

Need	Tool	Note
Show up on Google Maps and search	Google Business Profile	Free. The single most useful step.
Simple website	Google Sites	Free, easy, no coding.
Graphics, flyers, social posts	Canva	Free plan; Canva Pro is free for registered nonprofits.
Newsletter	Mailchimp or MailerLite	Free plans for small lists.
Sign-ups and feedback	Google Forms	Free. Link it from your site and newsletter.
Event calendar	Google Calendar	Free. Embed it on your website.
Short video editing	CapCut	Free app for phone or computer.
Schedule Instagram and Facebook posts	Meta Business Suite	Free. Write a month of posts in one sitting.
One link for everything	Linktree	Free. Put it in your Instagram bio.
Free ads for nonprofits	Google Ad Grants	For registered nonprofits. Takes setup.

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